

NEWS RELEASE

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TANDY CORPORATION/RADIO SHACK

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SUBJECT: Videotex and Office
Information System
(VIS)

Radio Shack Videotex and Office Information System (VIS)
Is a Microcomputer Information Storage, Retrieval
and Distribution System

Videotex and Office Information System (VIS) is an information storage, retrieval and distribution system from Tandy Corporation. A hardware and software package, VIS is designed to allow quick and easy access to large data bases stored in the desktop TRS-80® Model 16B Computer.

VIS is a two-way interactive system that transmits information electronically. Any terminal or computer with terminal capability may be used to receive and display text and, if compatible, graphics and computer programs.

VIS offers state-of-the-art technology at prices that are a fraction of the cost of comparable systems. Some features, such as multiple keyword/synonym access, are not available on any other system.

Data is established and organized by the information providers who define their user population, sell or provide information and information updates, and establish any security access rules. A system operator maintains the computer hardware and VIS software for either one or more information providers.

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As a private internal videotex system, VIS can meet the requirements of an information storage and delivery system within a company's internal operations, including daily schedules, policy files or as a bulletin board.

Using a computer in an office or a portable terminal from thousands of miles away, for example, VIS could allow checking of factory orders against usable inventory, corporate sales figures and production capacity, client or patient reports.

As a mass market system, VIS can be used as a "public" data base in which paid subscribers are allowed access to data such as news, weather and stock reports. Airline schedules, real estate multiple listing directories and credit bureau information are just a few of the many services possible with VIS.

A user may request a unit of information, called a "document," by entering the title, or by using one or more "keywords," words used as a cross-reference. VIS is so user-friendly it will accept misspelled words or retrieve alternatives based on phonetic similarities.

Since a user requesting information on two topics could possibly receive more information than needed, VIS features logical operators (and, or, exclusive or) to permit the user to target in on the exact documents required.

Information can also be accessed from "menus," a "user-friendly" operation for those who have little or no experience with data base systems.

All that is required to set up a basic VIS system is a two-disk TRS-80 Model 16B with 384K RAM, a 12-megabyte hard disk system, two modems and VIS software. This system can handle up to 200 incoming calls a day, assuming each call averages between five and 10 minutes each over a 24-hour period.

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From this basic configuration, a system can expand as necessary. Ultimately, the system operator can provide service to as many as 256 information providers per system. Additional hard disks can be added until the system could store all of the information contained in a complete set of encyclopedias. ASCII text is compressed before being stored on disk so that Radio Shack's 12-megabyte hard disk systems can effectively store 15 megabytes of text.

The VIS software was developed in highly modular form in the "C" programming language, and features an advanced back-up and recovery system. It is designed to be a continuously evolving product, with software enhancements made available to all system operators.

VIS operates with the TRS-80® Communications Multiplexor, for internal or external videotex systems. An eight-port version accepts eight incoming phone lines, while a 16-port version can service up to 16 users simultaneously.

VIS is compatible with virtually all TRS-80 desktop computers equipped with a 300-baud modem. Users may also utilize the TRS-80 Model 100 portable computer with built-in modem or a communications terminal.

The full VIS application software package is offered for a one-time \$3,500 license fee. An additional \$1,000 is charged for a multiplexor software support module, a device that acts as an "electronic funnel," assembling several information requests coming into the VIS host computer at one time.

For more information contact:

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